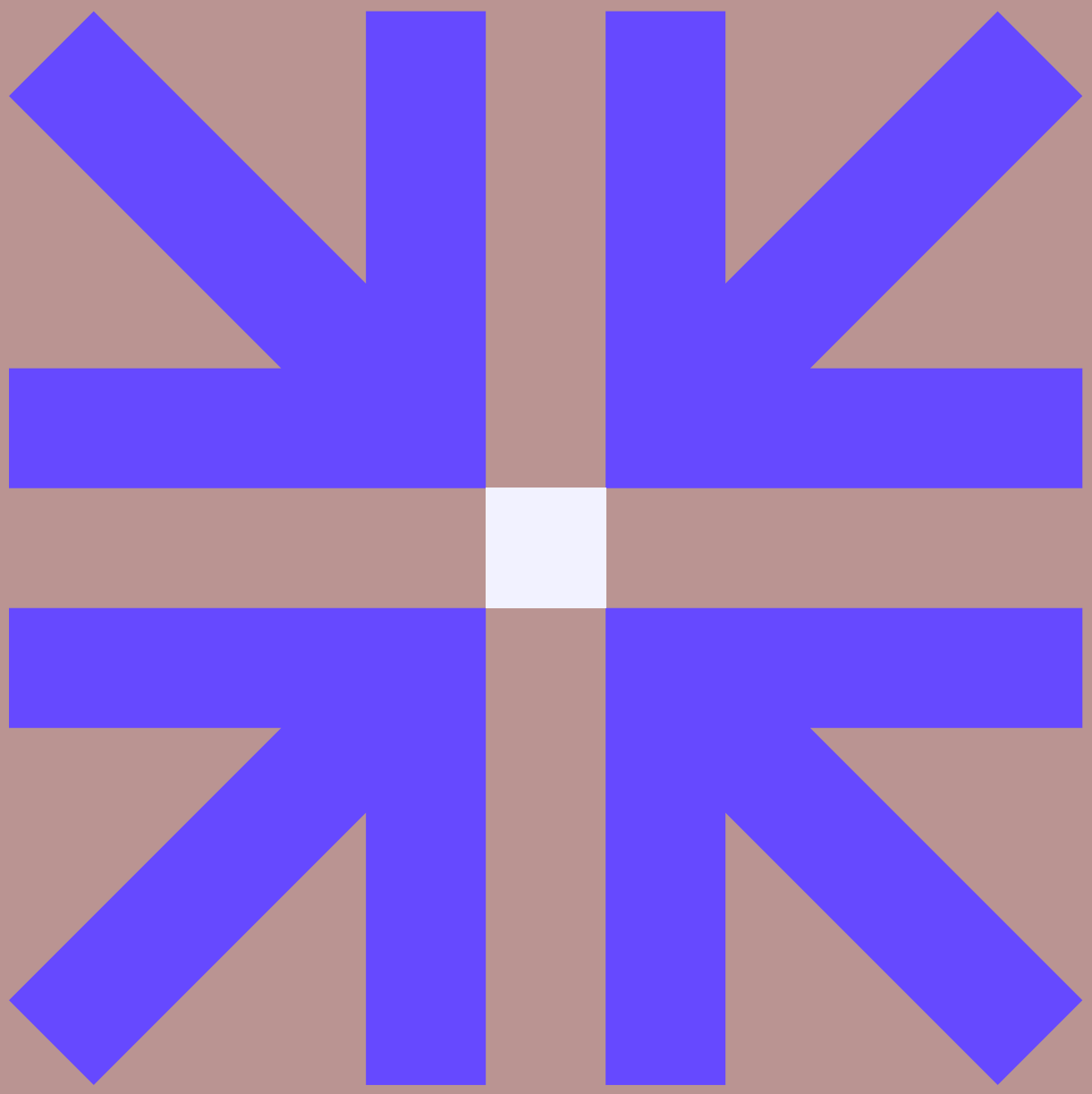
SiteScanly

The Small Business Guide to Website Security Checks



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Introduction

Website security can sound like something only large companies need to worry about, but that is rarely true. For a small business, a website security check is really about trust. It helps you spot problems that could make your site look unsafe, behave strangely, or quietly put people off getting in touch.

Small issues such as expired certificates, insecure page elements, or warning messages can be easy to miss until they start affecting confidence. A regular check helps you catch them early, understand what matters, and know what needs attention in plain English.

In this guide, we will cover:

01 What is a website security check?

02 SSL certificates and trust warnings

03 Mixed content and insecure elements

04 Other security basics worth checking

05 Signs your website may need attention

06 How SiteScanly can help

01

What is a website security check?

A website security check is a simple review of the parts of your site that help it load safely and look trustworthy. It is not about turning you into a security expert. It is about checking the basics, spotting risks early, and making sure your website still supports confidence in your business.

What it usually looks at:

- Whether your site uses HTTPS properly
- Whether the SSL certificate is valid and current
- Whether pages show browser trust warnings
- Whether forms, files, or page elements load securely
- Whether there are signs of unusual behaviour worth attention

In plain English, a website security check helps answer questions such as:

- Does my website look safe to visitors?
- Is anything likely to damage trust?
- Are there any obvious warning signs?
- Do I need to fix something now, or just keep an eye on it?

Think of it as part of a wider website health check. The goal is not perfection. The goal is reassurance. For a low-tech business owner, that means understanding what is fine, what needs attention, and what the next step should be.

Quick checklist:

- [ ] Your site loads securely
- [ ] Visitors are not seeing worrying messages
- [ ] Key pages still work as expected
- [ ] You have a clear view of any risks
- [ ] You know what to prioritise next

That is why it is useful for brochure sites, service businesses, and lead generation websites too. You do not need to sell online for website security to matter.

02

SSL certificates and trust warnings

SSL certificates are one of the most recognisable parts of website security because they help your site use HTTPS. In simple terms, they help prove that a visitor is connecting to your website safely. When that protection is missing, expired, or set up badly, browsers may show warnings that can damage confidence very quickly.

Why this matters:

- Visitors may see 'Not secure' warnings
- Contact or quote pages can feel unsafe
- People may leave before enquiring
- Trust can drop before your copy has even been read

Common problems to watch for:

- An expired certificate
- A certificate that was not renewed properly
- Only some pages using HTTPS
- Old links or redirects still pointing to insecure pages
- Website moves or hosting changes causing certificate issues

What a small business owner needs to know:

- You do not need to understand every technical detail
- You do need to know when trust warnings are appearing
- You do need to act quickly if key pages are affected

Simple priority list:

- Check whether the padlock appears
- Check whether important pages load securely
- Check whether customers are seeing warnings
- Get help if the certificate has expired or looks broken

An SSL certificate expiry check is often one of the most valuable parts of a website security check because it focuses on a problem visitors notice straight away.

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Mixed content and insecure elements

A website can appear secure at first glance and still have security problems underneath. One common example is mixed content. This happens when a page loads over HTTPS, but some of the files on that page, such as images, scripts, videos, or other resources, are still being pulled in over HTTP.

Why mixed content matters:

- A page can show a padlock but still have weak spots
- Browsers may block some insecure files
- Parts of the page may look broken or behave oddly
- Visitors may lose confidence if something does not load properly

You might notice:

- Missing images
- Odd page layout changes
- Forms or buttons acting strangely
- Browser warnings on certain pages only

Common causes:

- Old image links left in the site
- Embedded tools or plugins using old URLs
- Hard-coded files that were never updated
- Legacy content copied from an older version of the site

Mixed content checklist:

- [ ] Check key pages, not just the homepage
- [ ] Review pages with forms, downloads, or media
- [ ] Look for anything that loads inconsistently
- [ ] Flag anything that seems fine on one page but not another

A mixed content error fix is not always obvious to a business owner, but it is exactly the sort of issue a plain English website report should help explain clearly.

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Other security basics worth checking

A good website security check should not stop at SSL and HTTPS. There are other basics that help reduce risk and keep your site feeling reliable. These do not need to be explained in heavy technical language. What matters is understanding the business impact of each one.

Other basics worth checking:

- Login areas are protected with strong passwords
- Plugins, themes, or site systems are not badly out of date
- Contact forms are working and not attracting spam
- Admin access is limited to the right people
- Suspicious behaviour is not being ignored

Warning signs that deserve attention:

- A sudden rise in spam messages
- Strange new pages or content appearing
- Logins you do not recognise
- Website settings changing unexpectedly
- Emails from the site being flagged or going missing

Small business security checklist:

- [ ] Keep systems updated
- [ ] Remove anything you no longer use
- [ ] Limit who can access the site
- [ ] Watch for unusual behaviour
- [ ] Review the site regularly, not only when something breaks

This is where a website health report becomes useful. It brings several small checks together and turns them into something practical, calm, and easier to act on.

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Signs your website may need attention

Many owners do not start with a planned website security check. They start because something feels off. The challenge is that security problems are not always dramatic. Sometimes they show up as small bits of friction that are easy to dismiss at first.

Common warning signs:

- The browser shows a security warning
- The padlock has disappeared
- Pages load strangely or feel incomplete
- Customers mention the site looks odd
- You have changed hosts, domains, or platforms recently
- You cannot remember the last time the site was checked

Other clues worth noticing:

- Your website suddenly feels slower or less stable
- Enquiries drop after a site change
- Your email trust setup has not been reviewed in a long time
- You are relying on guesswork rather than a recent check

Use this simple self-check:

- [ ] Do I know whether my site is fully secure?
- [ ] Have I checked key pages recently?
- [ ] Would I notice quickly if trust warnings appeared?
- [ ] Do I know what I would fix first?

If the honest answer is 'not really', that is not a failure. It is simply a sign that a website audit for small business use could help bring things back into focus.

A good plain English website report does not wait for a major failure. It helps you spot these earlier signs before they turn into lost trust, missed enquiries, or a bigger clean-up job.

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How SiteScanly can help

SiteScanly is built for business owners who want clarity, not jargon. Instead of leaving you to decode technical alerts, it helps turn website security checks into plain-English actions you can actually understand. That matters when you are busy running a business and do not want to spend hours trying to work out which warnings matter.

What SiteScanly helps you see:

- What is working as it should
- What needs attention now
- What can be monitored over time
- Which issues may need technical help
- How security checks fit into your wider website health check

What that looks like in practice:

- A plain English website report
- Clear explanations instead of heavy technical terms
- Security-related findings placed in business context
- A calmer view of what is urgent and what is not
- Ongoing visibility through a monthly website checks service

What SiteScanly helps you see:

- You spend less time guessing
- You reduce the chance of quiet trust problems going unnoticed
- You have something clearer to share with a developer if fixes are needed
- You stay more confident about the health of your website

For a small business owner or sole trader, the value is simple. You get a website health report that helps you protect trust, catch issues early, and feel more in control of what your website is doing behind the scenes.

SiteScanly

Interested in a monthly website health report?

Go to sitescanly.com

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